

KING PENGUIN

Aptenodytes patagonicus

The king penguin is the second largest penguin species. Only its close cousin, the emperor penguin, is bigger. Unlike the emperor, the king inhabits sub-Antarctic islands. It hunts fish, ignoring the krill taken by many of its rivals, and dives to extraordinary depths to get them – sometimes to over 200 m (660 ft). It produces just one egg at a time and it takes more than a year to raise the single young. This means adults cannot breed annually and the enormous breeding colonies – containing juveniles of different ages – maintain a permanent presence on favoured islands of the southern oceans.

SIZE 90–100 cm (35–39 in)

HABITAT Flat coastal plains and waters around sub-Antarctic islands

DISTRIBUTION Islands of S. Atlantic and S. Indian Oceans

DIET Mostly lanternfish, occasionally squid

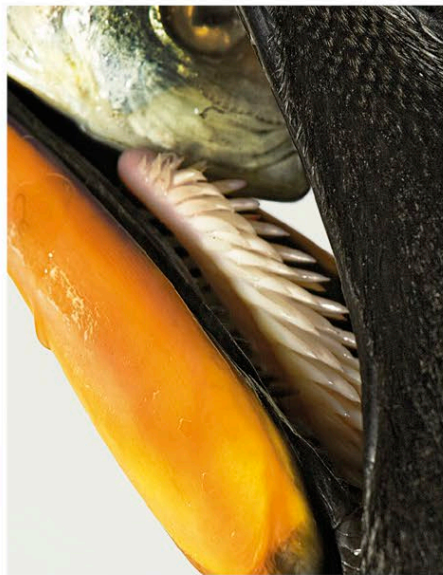
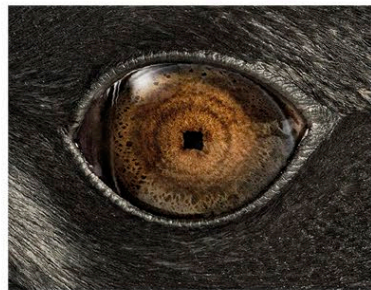


black upper mandible

penguins drink sea water and excrete excess salt as brine through the nostrils

✓ KEEN EYE

Penguins hunt by sight and have good underwater vision. Bioluminescent lanternfish, caught on night-time dives, predominate in the diet of this species.



< SPINY TONGUE

A penguin's tongue is muscular and spiny: projections on the tongue surface called papillae have evolved into backward-facing barbs that help grip fish caught in dives.

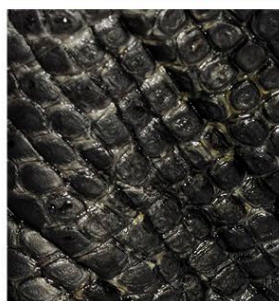


^ WING PROPULSION

Penguins are flightless birds, but they are propelled by feet and wings during dives. Their flipper-like wings effectively make them "fly" under water.

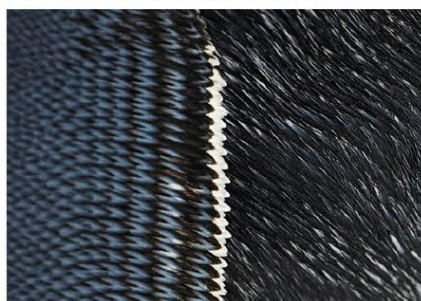
< DENSE FEATHERS

The feathers, arranged in an outer oily waterproof layer and inner downy insulating layers, are adapted for diving in cold water.



^ SCALY SKIN

Scales on the legs and feet are reminiscent of the reptilian roots of all birds; the dark skin may help to spread heat to eggs and young.



WEBBED FOOT >

The kicking action of webbed feet helps propel the bird forwards under water – and on land, when "tobogganing" over snow on its belly.



< FIRM TAIL

The short tail consists of stiffened feathers, used as a rudder under water. In smaller species, it is used as a prop on land.

^ EGG PROTECTOR

The single egg is incubated above the feet and beneath a fold of warm skin called a brood pouch. Once the chick has hatched, it uses the brood pouch for shelter.

